

J. L. MORENO AND THE PSYCHODRAMATIC METHOD

Beginning with a discussion of the intrinsic nature of psychodrama and providing the reader with a thorough description of the psychodramatic method, this book navigates the nature, applications, theories, and practices of the techniques originated by J. L. Moreno.

The book covers the work of the psychodrama pioneer in the field of mental health and discourse on his techniques. Methods of handling situations and scenarios that frequently arise in psychodrama sessions are described and amply illustrated with examples from actual psychodramas. The existential philosophy upon which psychodrama is founded, Moreno's Doctrine of Spontaneity-Creativity, and the theories important to understanding psychodrama are all discussed. The final chapter is devoted to the life and work of J. L. Moreno.

This book will be of great interest to psychodramatists, drama therapists, psychotherapists, and other mental health professionals who use the psychodramatic method in counseling and training programs.

John Nolte, PhD, has been a psychodramatic practitioner and trainer for more than 50 years. John has a doctorate in clinical psychology from Washington University and was trained in psychodrama by J. L. Moreno, MD, the originator of psychodrama and other action methods, and his wife, Zerka Moreno. He is certified as a Trainer-Educator-Practitioner by the American Board of Examiners in Psychodrama, Sociometry and Group Psychotherapy. He is recognized by the psychodrama community as a senior and respected practitioner of the Morenean methods as well as a seasoned trainer.



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John Nolte

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I never miss a chance to express my deepest gratitude to J. L. and Zerka T. Moreno for all they have given to my personal and professional life. This book is another attempt to honor their gifts by passing them along. I hope others will appreciate everything they have bestowed upon the world.

Thanks to the American Society of Group Psychotherapy and Psychodrama and to President Nancy Kirsner for permission to include the Canon of Creativity in this book, as well as for the use of the illustration on the cover.

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I am deeply grateful to Gerry Spence, great American trial lawyer, who welcomed me in my attempt to introduce psychodrama into the teaching methods of his Trial Lawyers College. Neither of us anticipated how extensively we would find ways of integrating the method into the College or how creative students of the College would discover ways of using psychodrama in their everyday work. Working with trial lawyers, who deserve a far more favorable reputation than they have, has been one of the top experiences in my career. Spence has been a powerful advocate for psychodrama and I thank him for all he has contributed to the method and to me.

Don Clarkson, friend and colleague for many years, is responsible for my initial invitation to the Trial Lawyers College, and I cannot thank him too much for making that opportunity possible. Kätlin Larimer and Kathie St. Clair are the other two psychodramatists par excellence who made the

Trial Lawyers College so creative. They are also my partners in the National Psychodrama Training Center.

When Nancy Drew and I joined our lives together, I gained not only a wife and life partner but an outstanding editor as well. She bears much of the responsibility for the presence of this book. She encouraged me, sometimes forcefully, to get it done. She read everything that I wrote, including material that I wrote and then eliminated, and liberally used her red pencil to point out to me passages which needed work to make them intelligible. More importantly, with her grounding in philosophy, especially phenomenology and existentialism, she has helped me understand Moreno to a much greater extent. I hereby express my deepest appreciation to her.

INTRODUCTION

My first contact with psychodrama occurred early in my graduate student career when I came across a one-paragraph description in a textbook. As I recall, many years later, it declared that psychodrama was a method of psychotherapy devised by an Italian psychiatrist named Moreno, and consisted of patients performing skits based on their life experiences. I was not impressed. I was avidly reading my way through Freud's *Collected Works*, trying to make sense of psychoanalytic theory, and anticipating a career of practicing a psychodynamic style of psychotherapy. Performing skits seemed like a very superficial sort of psychotherapy. I was interested in a much more serious method.

I first encountered psychodrama in the fall of 1959, when a group from St. Louis State Hospital came to the Fulton (Missouri) State Hospital, where I was a staff clinical psychologist, to demonstrate the method. The presenters were all people I had known as a graduate student at Washington University in St. Louis: Abel Ossario, graduate school professor; Leon Fine, a fellow graduate student; and Barbara Seabourne, a fellow psychology trainee at John Cochran V. A. Hospital. I suspect that, still thinking of psychodrama in terms of the first description that I had read, I might not have attended the two-day demonstration of psychodrama had it not been presented by old friends.

The first session was a demonstration of spontaneity testing, not a classical psychodrama. However, I found it intriguing. After the session, I walked across the campus with my good friend, John Miller. We were in a very active discussion of what we had experienced, trying to figure out why the director had given the directions he had given, what the significance of the event was. Suddenly I stopped. "John," I said to my friend, "if psychodrama can get me this worked up, I think I need to find out more about it." I arranged to spend

a few days at the St. Louis State Hospital with the psychodrama program headed by Leon Fine. Then, in the summer of 1962, I spent two weeks at the Moreno Institute. As psychodrama so often does to those who experience it, those two weeks changed the course of my life and I left committed to the psychodramatic method. It was also the first of many weeks I spent at the Institute, over a period of 14 years.

Since then, I have participated in at least five thousand psychodrama sessions as protagonist, director, auxiliary ego, training supervisor, and audience member. I have practiced psychodramatic psychotherapy in a state hospital and on psychiatric, substance abuse, and chronic pain services in several general hospitals, as well as in outpatient clinics. I have used psychodrama in organizational and staff development activities. I have employed role training with medical students and surgical residents and I have conducted in-service training sessions with nurses. I have utilized psychodrama in a university literature class. I have trained trial lawyers in trial skills and have made use of psychodrama in trial preparation. I have conducted training workshops in psychodrama for almost 50 years. I have served as Director of Training for the Moreno Institute.

I had a desire early in my psychodramatic career, while I was still very much a student of the method, to write about psychodrama, to write about spontaneity and warming up, surplus reality, role playing, and all the rest. I made many starts—but they all ended up way short of my goals and useless. What I didn't know then was that I didn't know nearly enough to articulate what I was learning and experiencing. I did write and co-write papers, some of which were published and some which were hand-outs for many presentations which I made at the Annual Conferences of the American Society of Group Psychotherapy and Psychodrama (ASGPP). A few years ago, I self-published them through Lulu.com as *The Psychodrama Papers*. When I finally got a “real” book thoroughly underway (Nolte, 2014), to the point that I thought I really could complete it, I discovered that it was turning out to be a book on J. L. Moreno's philosophy and theories. I added a section on methods as well. I also came to the realization that I was writing for discovery, to discover and put into words what I knew. I realized as well that this was what my first attempts to write about Moreno's ideas were about and that I simply did not have sufficient experience to accomplish what I wanted.

Several books whose titles suggest that there have been significant advances in psychodramatic theory, techniques, or practice, e.g. Holmes, Karp and Watson (1994); Gershoni (2003); Baim, Burmeister and Maciel (2007), have been published since Moreno's death in 1974. Although I do believe that the practice of psychodrama has changed since the Moreno Institute, representing the state of the art of psychodrama practice, ceased to exist, I am not convinced that practice has advanced. In fact, at the risk of being considered a troglodyte, I am of the opinion that psychodrama as generally practiced has

suffered and is a less powerful method in the hands of many of today's psychodramatists than it was in Moreno's time. There are certainly exceptions to this statement. The practice of psychodrama presented in this book is the psychodramatic method as it was taught at the Moreno Institute in the 1960s and 1970s, the period during which I was associated with the Institute either as a student, staff member, or Director of Training. It reflects Zerka Moreno's style. I consider her my trainer, J. L. the originator. From him, I got the philosophy and theory. I am deeply and eternally grateful to both.

My hope is that those who read this book will find something in it that they did not already know, and that they will be glad that they learned. I expect that there will be readers who disagree with something that I have written. I will be disappointed if there are not. I would like to hear from all. Consider this, in Moreno's famous words, as my *Invitation to an Encounter*.

There are nine chapters in the book. The first five have to do with classical protagonist-centered psychodrama. This is psychodrama as it is employed for psychotherapy and for personal growth and development. The sixth chapter describes how psychodrama is and has been used for nonclinical objectives. Moreno was pained that his methods had often been adopted (and often modified), but separated from the theories and philosophy upon which they were based. Therefore, I would consider it amiss not to include a long chapter on Morenean theory, Chapter 7. Chapter 8 is a brief history of the psychodramatic method and Chapter 9 is my understanding of what J. L. Moreno was all about.

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1

WHAT IS PSYCHODRAMA, ANYWAY?

Role playing is a universal activity among children of all cultures. As children, we learn from older children or re-invent it ourselves. We teach school, explore outer space as astronauts, search for treasure buried by pirates, play doctor or cow-boys and Indians, and engage in all sort of adventures. There are even suggestions that role playing is an evolutionary legacy from pre-human species. Philosophers, Rousseau, Froebel, and Dewey for example, had long pointed out that play was important in children's learning. It took the genius of J. L. Moreno, however, to transform the role-playing games of childhood into the organized, coherent, and structured method of psychodrama, that has since been employed in multiple ways, in education and training; in psychotherapy; in personal growth and development; and in social research.

More than a Method of Psychotherapy

The most common definition of psychodrama is based on its most widely applied function¹ as a method of psychotherapy, in which people act out the problematic situations in their current lives and troublesome ones from their past experiences instead of merely describing them as happens in conventional psychotherapies. The definition of psychodrama as a method of psychotherapy, however, greatly obscures the fact that it is a method which has several distinctly different applications. It is far more than just a psychotherapeutic method. In 1948, Ronald Levy wrote that in a broad general sense, psychodrama "includes the whole family of skills, techniques, and processes which are involved in the 'unrehearsed' but not unplanned, dramatization of human problems for the purpose of dealing with them more effectively" (p. 226).

2 What Is Psychodrama, Anyway?

Generically, psychodrama is a method of creating dramas, a systematized form of children's creative role playing. It is a *dramaturgy*, an art form. As such, it is also a *method of communication*. Psychodrama is a way to explore, understand, and express one's subjective experience, a *method of personality development*. Psychodrama is also a *method of training*, an *educational process*, and a *research instrument*. All these activities are legitimate functions of the psychodramatic method.

When he first offered training in his methods, psychodrama and sociometry, Moreno announced that his courses comprised educational, guidance, and marital counseling, mental disorders, and social maladjustment as subjects. The courses were open to educators, ministers, and counselors of all kinds, in addition to psychiatrists, social workers, and psychologists. It was clear that he saw psychodrama as far more than a psychotherapeutic method in the customary definition of medical psychiatry. The fact was that he saw therapy in a far broader sense than that of psychiatry. As a result, all students, whether counselors, therapists, teachers, or others, were taught the same thing—the basic psychodrama method. Moreno's concept of group psychotherapy as the therapy of the group rather than treatment of individuals in a group setting, and his mantra of “every person the therapist of every other person,” were embedded in all the training at his Psychodramatic Institute.

A Dramaturgy

The lowest common denominator of psychodrama's functions is creating dramas. Every psychodrama, even if it is only a few minutes long, is indeed a dramatic piece. It is different from the conventional drama in that it does not require a script, trained actors, rehearsals, carefully constructed scenery, or costumes and props. In conventional theater, a proscenium arch separates the audience from the actors and the action. The psychodrama stage is easily accessible to the audience, from which come the protagonist and auxiliary players. A psychodrama is produced spontaneously in the moment, without a script, without rehearsals, scenery, and costumes, and with a minimum of props. The protagonist and actors emerge from the audience and return to it. Rather than to interpret an author's work, the role of the director is to assist the protagonist to communicate her or his subjective experiences in dramatic form. That psychodrama is a *dramaturgy* also means that psychodrama is an art form.

A Method of Communication

There are many wonderful definitions of art (Popova, 2012). One of my favorites is: “A work of art is a message to the world, from the world, about the world.”² Psychodrama is without question a method of communication. It provides a unique and powerful way to convey to others what we have

experienced in our lives. The audience is invited to be present as we recreate and act out events and fantasies complete with our thoughts and our feelings. In psychodrama, the protagonist doesn't tell a story from his or her life. He or she *re-lives* an experience, a wish, a dream, or a fantasy in the presence of the audience. In the process, the actions, interactions, thoughts, and emotions of the protagonist and of all the other individuals involved are portrayed in a richness, intensity, depth, vibrancy, and completeness that goes far beyond narrative. We observe and participate in the protagonist's tribulation, pain, joy, triumph, and celebration. We see the protagonist and his or her life as the protagonist experiences it.

The most important communication is the protagonist's communication with him or herself. Through reenactment of experiences, the protagonist extracts information that has remained hidden and inaccessible. The protagonist thus comes to know her or himself more thoroughly. Through psychodrama, one makes sense out of events that have heretofore been confusing, baffling, perplexing, or bewildering.

A Method of Psychotherapy

The most extensive application of psychodrama has been in the mental health field. This is not surprising since Moreno was a psychiatrist who first employed spontaneity drama techniques to resolve troubles in a distressed marriage in the early 1920s. Moreno developed the psychotherapeutic function of psychodrama in conjunction with his establishment of a psychiatric hospital, Beacon Hill Sanitarium in Beacon, NY, in 1936. The protagonists of the early psychodramas were psychiatric patients. Psychodrama, with its emphasis upon interpersonal relationships, reflected Moreno's conviction that psychiatric symptoms result from interpersonal problems rather than from internal conflicts. This was contrary to the conventional viewpoint, the medical model of mental illness. For Moreno, treatment was focused on relationships, groups, and society at large.

Psychodrama is uniquely designed to achieve what psychotherapy seeks to do, i.e., to provide relief from emotional distress. By replicating direct experience in a flexible and controlled setting, psychodrama provides deep insight into the genesis of one's actions. The action insight that the protagonist earns from psychodramatic work is deeper and far more effective than the cognitive insight a client receives from conventional psychotherapy.

Personality Development

"Know thyself," the famous Greek aphorism often attributed to Socrates, has elicited similar points of view over the centuries, for example:

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I must first know myself, as the Delphian inscription says; to be curious about that which is not my concern, while I am still in ignorance of my own self would be ridiculous.

Plato

He who knows others is wise; he who knows himself is enlightened.

Lao Tzu

Make it thy business to know thyself, which is the most difficult lesson in the world.

Miguel de Cervantes

Observe all men; thy self most.

Benjamin Franklin

Other expressions incorporating the notion of self knowledge with an emphasis on being include:

“Know Thyself” was written over the portal of the antique world. Over the portal of the new world, “Be Thyself” shall be written.

Oscar Wilde

We only become what we are by the radical and deep-seated refusal of that which others have made of us.

Jean-Paul Sartre

Without self knowledge, without understanding the working and functions of his machine, man cannot be free, he cannot govern himself and he will always remain a slave.

G. I. Gurdjieff

Psychodrama reflects the spirit of all of these views.

Expanded understanding of oneself, insight, is a basic principle of most methods of psychotherapy. However, one need not have a psychiatric problem to desire, seek, and benefit from greater self awareness and self understanding. Moreno sometimes described psychodrama as therapy for normal people.³ Psychodrama is a powerful method for the re-examination of one's life experiences, especially those that are associated with strong positive or negative emotion. Highly functional people find value in participating in activities that generate insight. These include psychotherapies of many kinds, personal growth and development groups, and psychodrama training groups where people have opportunities for exploring puzzling and problematic events in their lives. Psychodrama, which involves the

whole person physically, mentally, and socially, is the most powerful approach to the task of greater self understanding.

For several decades in the last half of the twentieth century, the human potential movement consisted of a wide variety of workshops often labeled as human skills training, personal growth and development workshops, or as encounter groups. These events made use of psychotherapeutic techniques as well as techniques developed from small group research. They promised increased personal effectiveness. Jonathan Moreno (2014) discusses the history of the human potential movement and its relationship to the theory and methods of J. L. Moreno at length in his book about his father. The psychodrama training workshops of the Moreno Institute provided a prototype for these events. Personal growth activities are differentiated from psychotherapy in that the latter is considered remedial, treatment of a disorder, while the former involves expansion of self understanding and social effectiveness.

Social Skills or Role Training

One of the earliest nonclinical applications of psychodrama was role training, a form of psychodrama that prepares a person to meet future situations. Role training allows one to experience anticipated difficult situations on the psychodrama stage and to practice responding to them in a safe setting. Psychodramatic techniques were used for training as early as 1928 when Moreno conducted role training sessions for managers of Macy's Department Store (J. D. Moreno, 2014). A few years later, Moreno was deeply immersed in his pioneering sociometric research project at the New York Training School for Girls at Hudson. One of the problems he confronted was preparing students for successful living in open society after discharge from the institution. In the first edition of *Who Shall Survive?* Moreno (1934) describes role-playing sessions in which the students of the New York State Training School for Girls were put in situations that they might expect to experience after leaving the institution. Since then, role training or some modification of it has found widespread usage in many venues and especially in business and industrial situations where it is often referred to as role play. Moreno sometimes called role training "rehearsal for living."

Noted industrial psychologist Norman R. F. Maier made extensive use of psychodramatic role playing in the business world. Maier worked with large industries on the problems of improving supervision. The program was focused on moving leadership from an autocratic model to a more democratic one. In his books (1952, 1953, 1955) Maier describes many ways in which role playing can be used to introduce human relations training into the industrial setting.

Psychodrama in Education

Psychodrama has been creatively employed by teachers and instructors in many disciplines. In literature, for example, a class turns a discussion into dramatic form. Narrative is enacted. Students take the roles of characters, expanding on the roles and answering questions that other class members may have. A systematic approach to psychodramatization of literary works is called bibliodrama and has been written about by Miller (1998, 2000, 2002; Pitzele, 1998).

The first article in the journal, *Sociometry*, documenting the use of a psychodrama in a formal teaching setting, appeared in 1939 when J. G. Franz of Columbia University reported using spontaneity training with students in a public speaking course. The first book on Morenean methods in the field of education, *Psychodrama and Sociometry in American Education*, was published in 1949 (Haas). It consisted of more than 30 articles by as many authors describing a wide range of applications from early elementary grades through junior high school, high school, and college levels to community projects.

Since 1934, there have been dozens, if not hundreds of articles in professional journals and books describing or advocating the use of psychodrama for teaching. In addition to the term psychodrama, the authors of these papers have used the labels sociodrama, spontaneity training, role training, simulations, and role playing in describing the use of spontaneity methods for teaching an exceptionally wide range of subjects. A cursory search of the JSTOR archive resulted in papers reporting the use of the spontaneity drama in method in more than 25 different subjects ranging from aesthetics and accounting through history and literature to philosophy and sociology. The creativity of the teachers who designed these events is awe-inspiring. Teachers who have written about role playing experiences are enthusiastic about the method. The number of events reported in professional journals is probably an infinitesimally small percentage of the total number of role playing events in the classroom.

Research

Because it highlights social interaction, psychodrama and its sibling method, sociodrama, provide a unique method for conducting social research. Reenactment methods have been extensively used in social psychological research. A modification of psychodrama, reenactment interviewing, has been successfully applied to qualitative research (Drew, 1993). Research is a greatly under-used function of psychodrama.

The Current Status of Psychodrama

Psychodrama has never achieved the popularity in the mental health field in America to which its effectiveness entitles it. The number of certified

psychodramatists has remained between 400 and 450 for some years, although the number of actual practitioners may be twice that. In addition, many practitioners of other methods include psychodramatic interventions in their work. On the other hand, psychodrama has found popularity in South American countries, especially Argentina and Brazil where estimates run as high as 6,000 psychodramatists. The same is true in Europe where there are training programs and practitioners of the method in many countries.

Notes

- 1 I first heard Jim Enneis, founder and long-time director of the Psychodrama Training Program of St. Elizabeth Hospital, use the term, *function*, for the different applications of psychodrama. Considering its dictionary definition as “the action for which a person or thing is specially fitted or used or for which a thing exists,” it seems a very appropriate word in this context.
- 2 From Matt Parrish, a good friend who was himself an artist and musician as well as a great psychiatrist. I do not know if it is original with him but suspect that it is.
- 3 The number of self-help books in print indicates that there is an extensive feeling among people that they are not as effective as they wish or think that they should be. The human potential movement, also known as the encounter group movement, was a response to that feeling.

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NOTES

Chapter 1

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Chapter 4

- 1 Certification was originally offered only by the Moreno Institute. After Moreno's death, a certification board, The American Board of Certification in Psychodrama, Sociometry and Group Psychotherapy was established by the American Society for Group Psychotherapy and Psychodrama. Training requirements for the Certified Practitioner certificate include 780 hours of training with a certified trainer. There are additional requirements for certification.

Chapter 7

- 1 There are echoes here of Moreno's first publication, *Ein Ladung zu Einer Begegnung* (*Invitation to an Encounter*), in which Moreno first points to the problems and dangers of over valuing the conserve, especially the cultural, or manmade, conserve. From

Moreno's perspective, it would have been much better to meet Sorokin in person and discuss their ideas about spontaneity and creativity than to write and send articles to each other.

Chapter 8

- 1 This is similar to the current practice of some family therapists and the concept of identified patient. This is usually a child whose disruptive behavior has brought family into treatment. The disruptive behavior is considered the signal of dysfunction in the family social system.

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